

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear “so what for your school” line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, [get in touch](#).

TOP LINE

- Labour's conference in Liverpool (running to tomorrow) produced two lines with real classroom weight: new vocational GCSEs alongside the traditional set from 2029, and a demand that schools 'go further' than existing RSHE teaching to shift the wider culture on misogyny.
- The OECD published its Education at a Glance 2026 report today, with this year's special focus on teacher shortages — previous editions have flagged England as having one of the OECD's worst teacher attrition rates.

DATES FOR THE DIARY

30 Sep 2026 — Labour's annual conference in Liverpool closes; the PE and sport premium digital expenditure return is also due by 5pm the same day.

22 Oct 2026 — NEU national executive reconvenes to decide whether and when to relaunch the paused strike ballot.

LABOUR CONFERENCE: TWO LINES FOR SCHOOLS

■ **New vocational GCSEs confirmed for 2029.** Education secretary Lucy Powell used her conference speech to confirm vocational GCSEs — covering subjects like construction, child development and business — sitting alongside traditional GCSEs from as early as September 2029. She rejected the 'dumbing down' charge, calling them 'very hard subjects' with real maths and problem-solving content. (LBC)

→ **For your school:** *Four years out, but worth a mention to your curriculum/options lead as a future pathway for pupils the current GCSE offer doesn't serve well.*

■ **Schools told to 'go further' on misogyny.** Powell said schools must move beyond this year's RSHE strategy and embed healthy relationships 'into every part of school life, not just RSHE lessons', including teaching on deepfakes, image-based abuse and online harassment. Her line: 'We simply cannot just teach our way out of misogyny.' (Tes)

→ **For your school:** *Worth checking with your PSHE/RSHE lead that deepfakes and image-based abuse are explicitly covered, not folded into a generic online-safety unit.*

DATA POINT OF THE WEEK

~10%

of England's teachers left the profession in the most recent year the OECD measured — over three times the rate in France or Ireland. That was last year's Education at a Glance; this year's edition, published today with a fresh focus on teacher shortages, will show whether the gap has moved. Figure unconfirmed for the 2026 edition at time of writing.

OECD, Education at a Glance (2025 data); 2026 edition published 29 September 2026

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. [Explore School+](#)

■ SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.